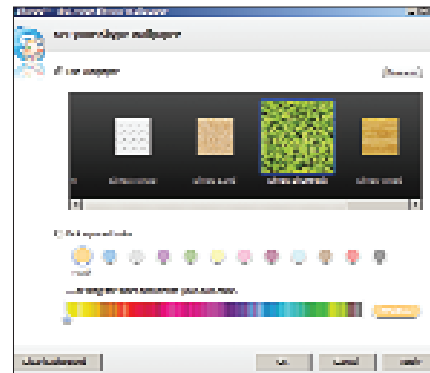


a new group. You can now drag and drop existing contacts from your list into any of these groups.

The Groups feature allows for flexibility. For example, you can right-click on a group, say all your colleagues, and click Start Group Chat. You can also send contacts and files (like we mentioned).



Give Skype a makeover!

Giving Skype Some Style

Skype hasn't changed a lot through the years. There are few settings that can improve on the default look. You can change the wallpaper (the background you see on your Skype window). Go to File > Personalize > Change Wallpaper. There are many preset wallpapers you can choose from. Other than that, you can set a custom wallpaper by clicking on Browse. You can choose a plain colour by clicking on the Pick a preset color radio button and then using the slider to select a colour.

Enabling Keyboard Shortcuts

Keyboard shortcuts for Skype are disabled by default; they can be enabled by selecting Tools > Options. Click on Advanced and then on Hotkeys. Check the box that says Enable keyboard shortcuts. You can change the shortcuts and enable and disable

them as well. This should allow you to be able to control Skype without having it in focus.

Installing Add-ons For Skype

You can enhance the functionality of Skype using add-ons. Go to Tools > Do More > Organize your Extras. Here, you can choose from a categorised list of add-ons. Some of these might require that you have Skype Credit. Here are some that are worth trying; click on the green Open link on an add-on to download and install it.

FFDSHOW

ffdshow is a filter that can be used to decode a huge number of formats, which means you don't have to go about installing all those codecs out there. Media Player Classic and ffdshow work as a great combo, and we will be using MPC to demonstrate some of ffdshow's features. ffdshow is constantly under development, and new releases are brought out very often. <http://ffdshow-tryout.sourceforge.net/> and <http://www.x264.nl/> are good sites to find updates for ffdshow. These updates bring in optimisations like better support for multi-core processors. If you're using the K-Lite codec pack that's on our CDs, you'll have ffdshow installed.

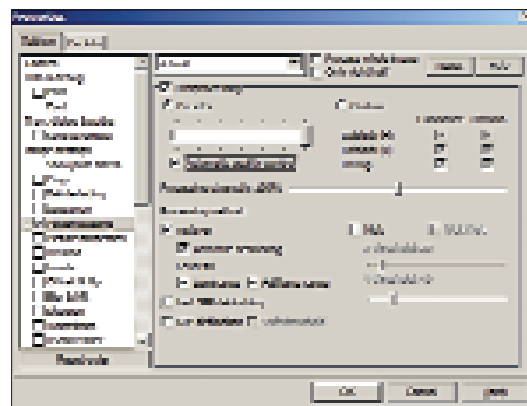
Disabling ffdshow For Codecs

It's a similar problem for ffdshow with some codecs (like with some applications). Certain codecs won't work as well with ffdshow as with some others. Like we'll soon mention, ffdshow has quality enhancements settings which can cause performance drops. To disable ffdshow for a particular codec, right-click on the playing video, select Filters >

ffdshow Video Decoder, then choose Codecs. Under the Decoder column, click the current decoder and choose a new decoder for the codec. Restart the player or the video to check if it works. If you get a blank output for that format, follow the same steps and set it to the previous decoder.

Enabling Deblocking And Other Quality Enhancements

One of ffdshow's unique features is the ability to enhance the quality of video. Most of the videos we watch are heavily



Deblocking can help reduce the pixelation you see on highly-compressed and low-resolution videos

compressed, and some of them have pixelation, which is especially noticeable on large LCD screens. You can reduce this by enabling deblocking. Right-click on the playing video and select Filters > ffdshow Video Decoder. Check the box that says Postprocessing. To get an idea of how much the quality enhancements are affecting the video, check the Only right half box. Check one of the processing modes available and set a processing strength using the slider. When you're pleased with the quality, uncheck the Only right half checkbox and click the Process whole image checkbox. Click OK to finish.

Some of these processing methods can be highly CPU-intensive, so you might want to select a different processing method such as fast SPP deblocking. Lowering the processing strength (by moving the Processing Strength slider) can also help.

Changing Contrast Ratios And Levels

The other type of enhancement can be done to the colour saturation and contrast levels of the video. The parameters can be different from video to video, but if, generally, you find abnormalities in the amount of colour, you can change it. Right-click on the Media Player Classic window with a video running, and click Filters >



mIRC

A quick guide to mIRC, the ultimate IRC client!

Rossi Fernandes

IRC (Internet Relay Chat) is a real-time communication system that was around before the first instant messenger in 1996. Even today, it is used by communities of all kinds—from software developers to gamers.

Development on mIRC is not as active as it used to be, but it's still the tool of choice for IRC users.

Automatically Connecting To Channels

In mIRC, every time you connect to a server, you need to join a channel to chat with people in that channel. It can be irritating to have to type the join command every time you want to join a channel. Select Favorites > Organize Favorites, and click Add. Enter the channel name with a hash sign, #linux, for example. Click Add to choose the network on which the channel exists, select the server on which the channel exists, and click OK. Check Join on connect and click OK. Next time you connect to the server, you will be automatically connected.

Another easy way to join a channel is to create a Windows shortcut to the channel. Right click on the Desktop (or any folder, for that matter) and select New > Shortcut. Enter the location as `irc://ServerName/ChannelName`, for example, `irc://irc.freenode.net/linux`. Double-click the icon and mIRC will join the channel and server.

Highlighting Your Nick

IRC users usually keep their clients in channels all day, idling. You obviously won't be looking at mIRC all the time, so you're going to miss out on the conversations going on (in the channel) that may have been directed at you. The highlight feature highlights your nick every time anyone calls it out. Select Tools > Address Book, then the Highlight tab. Check Enable highlight. In the field for choosing the words that trigger the highlight, enter \$me to have your nick highlighted. Choose the type of alerts you'd want—colours, sounds, alert messages—whatever. Click OK when done. In the same manner, you can add more keywords to be highlighted, and also use wildcards with the words.

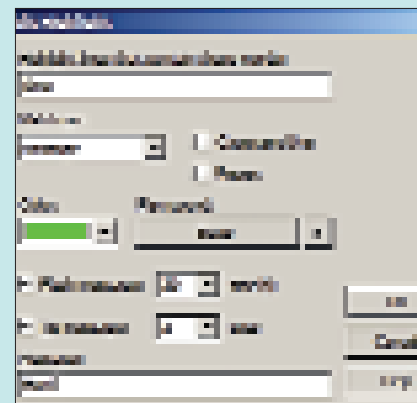
Setting Nick Colours

Chat rooms can have hundreds of people, with many of them chatting at

the same time, so it's difficult to make out if your friends are chatting—there are so many messages scrolling by so quickly! mIRC can highlight your friends' nicks. Select Tools > Address Book and then Nick Colors. Check Enable nick colors. Click Add, then enter the nick you want to highlight. Set a nick colour from the drop-down menu and click OK.

Customising Colours

When you're staring at channels, the default black text on a white background can be distracting. Recent versions of mIRC come with a few presets.

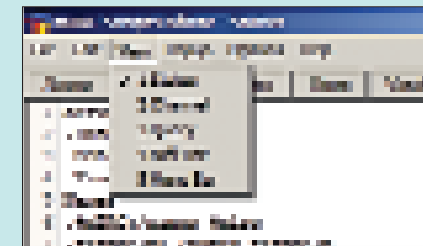


Have alerts come up when anyone mentions your name on IRC

Click on View > Colors. Choose from one of the schemes in the drop-down menu. You can customise the colours as well; to change fonts, select View > Font. Select the font and click the checkbox that says Set as default channel font (if you want to use this font for all channel windows).

Creating Your Own Menus

You'll notice that if you right-click in any window or on a nickname, there are menus that allow access to certain functions. You can add your own functions and menus. Go to Tools > Script Editor > Popups. Choose, from the View menu, for which window you want to create the pop-ups. Enter a name for a menu or function. To create a submenu, add a dot in front of the menu name, for example, .Menu1. To set a function for a menu item, enter the name of the menu followed by a colon and the command, for example, Join Linux:/join #linux. This will create a menu item called Join Linux. Clicking it will make you join the channel called linux. These



Make your own pop-up menus for your favourite actions

menus can be handy for tasks like quickly switching status, joining channels, and making actions. Remember, however, that there's a lot more that can be done with mIRC scripting!

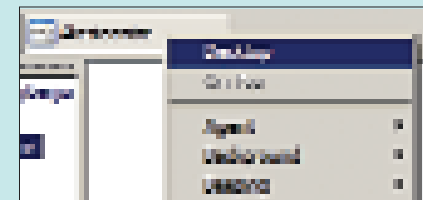
Connecting To Multiple Servers

All your favourite channels might not be on the same server, so you need to switch servers to join them. Fortunately, mIRC added support for multiple servers so users could stay connected on many servers at once. Go to File > Select Server. Select the network and double-click the server you want to connect to. Check the New server window box. Click Connect; a new window will appear, and the connection to the server will be made. There is another way to create a new server window while connecting to the server—if you know the exact address of the server. Enter `/server -m irc.ServerName.com`. For example, `/server -m irc.freenode.net` will create a new server window and connect to Freenode.

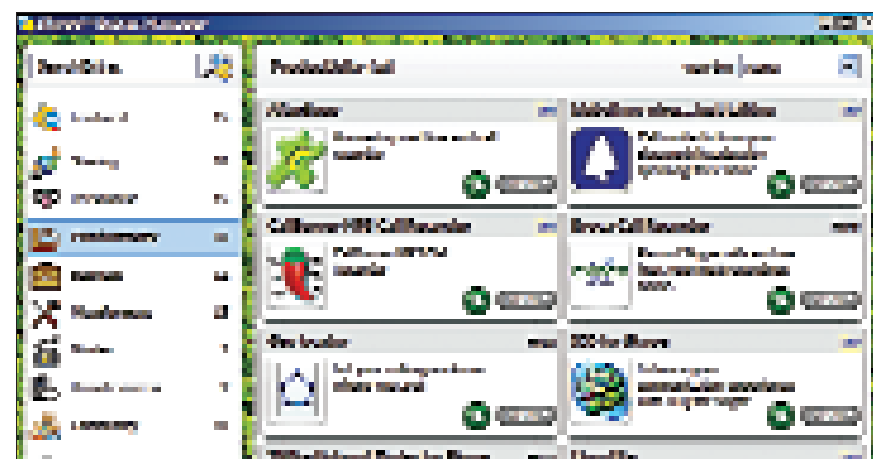
Undock A Channel Window

The mIRC interface houses smaller channel windows within it. When you want to chat on only one of the many channels you're on, you can undock the window from the mIRC interface and have it run in a full-screen window. Right-click on the tab you want to undock and click Desktop. To send the undocked window back to mIRC at any point, right-click on the window's menu and click Desktop again. ■

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Undock your favourite channel away from mIRC's flooded interface



The Extras Manager has a showcase of add-ons for Skype